

CHESS MASTERY LIBRARY | FIRST EDITION

Checklists, Glossary, and Study Map

A compact reference for daily use

THE PROMISE

Keep the library searchable with concise definitions, decision prompts, and a long-term mastery map.

VOLUME 15 OF 15

READ | RECALL | DECIDE | RETEST

What this volume should change

- Use short checklists without turning them into slow rituals.
- Recall the vocabulary connecting tactics, strategy, openings, and endgames.
- Choose the next study target from evidence in your games.

HOW TO STUDY

Read one section. Close the PDF and state its decision rule from memory. Solve the position lab before viewing the answer. Revisit the lab after two days and again after one week.

Inside this volume

01	Universal move checklist
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This volume is an original teaching synthesis of established chess ideas. Positions marked illustrative are designed to isolate a decision, not to replace full-game analysis. Board diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork from Lichess, licensed GPLv2+.

Universal move checklist

Use this full checklist in training and compress it in play. The point is consistent coverage, not robotic recitation.

Position cues

- What changed on the opponent's last move?
- What checks, captures, threats, and loose pieces exist?
- What is the most important positional feature?
- What are my forcing, necessary, improving, and restricting candidates?
- What is the opponent's best reply to each serious candidate?
- At the leaf, who has material, safety, activity, structure, space, and initiative?
- Before moving: destination, departure, enemy checks and captures.

PRACTICE RULE

Rehearse the full version slowly until the compressed version feels natural.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

If the checklist consumes the entire clock, you have not yet separated critical moves from stable ones.

Tactical vocabulary

Use motif names to direct attention, then calculate.

Position cues

- Fork or double attack: one move attacks two targets.
- Pin: a piece is constrained by a more valuable piece behind it.
- Skewer: the valuable front piece moves, exposing the rear target.
- Deflection: a defender is forced away from its duty.
- Decoy: a piece is lured onto a vulnerable square.
- Interference: a line between defender and target is blocked.
- Overload: one defender cannot perform two necessary jobs.
- Zwischenzug: a forcing move inserted before the expected continuation.

PRACTICE RULE

For each term, recall one trigger and one position from your own games.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

A name recognized after seeing the solution is not tactical vision.

These terms are useful only when connected to access and plans.

- Outpost: a safe square not conveniently challenged by pawns.
- Weakness: a target or square that is difficult to defend and can be accessed.
- Pawn break: a pawn move that challenges a chain or opens lines.
- Prophylaxis: reducing the opponent's plan, preferably with a useful move.
- Initiative: the ability to make threats that require responses.
- Space: controlled territory that grants maneuvering room.
- Transformation: a move or exchange that changes the strategic type of position.

When using a term in analysis, finish with 'therefore I should consider...'.

Labels without candidate moves can create the illusion of explanation.

Endgame vocabulary

Endgame terms describe mechanisms and should predict moves.

Position cues

- Key square: a king square that guarantees a pawn's promotion in a basic ending.
- Opposition: king geometry used to gain or deny entry.
- Zugzwang: any move worsens the position.
- Triangulation: a maneuver that loses a tempo and changes the side to move.
- Cutoff: a rook prevents the enemy king from crossing a rank or file.
- Bridge: rook shelter used in Lucena-family wins.
- Checking distance: space needed for safe, effective rook checks.

PRACTICE RULE

Set up a minimal board for each term and demonstrate the mechanism from both sides.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Knowing the name 'Philidor' does not prove you can find the defensive transition.

Error classification map

Classify errors by the first failed step. This determines the drill.

Position cues

- Perception: did not notice a threat, loose piece, or changed line.
- Candidate generation: the right move never entered consideration.
- Calculation: candidate seen, branch evaluated inaccurately.
- Evaluation: final position judged with wrong priorities.
- Knowledge: lacked a structure, opening, or endgame mechanism.
- Practical process: rushed, overthought, panicked, or misused the clock.

PRACTICE RULE

Tag only the earliest meaningful cause. A later tactical collapse may have begun with a missed opponent plan.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not label every loss 'calculation.' Different causes require different training.

Long-term mastery map

Chess expertise is built by cycling through the same domains at increasing depth. There is no final secret chapter; strength comes from integration and accuracy.

Position cues

- Foundation: legal geometry, safety, basic tactics, elementary mates and endings.
- Competence: candidate method, calculation, evaluation, core structures, coherent openings.
- Integration: transformation, prophylaxis, defensive resources, practical choices.
- Personalization: recurring errors, repertoire positions, style-independent weaknesses.
- Refinement: deeper calculation, endgame precision, opponent preparation, and tournament routines.

PRACTICE RULE

Every month, choose one domain to maintain and one bottleneck to improve. Use games as the evidence source.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

Do not wait to 'finish chess knowledge' before playing. Play, diagnose, study, and retest form one loop.

Library navigation index

Use the symptom to choose a volume rather than reading at random.

Position cues

- I blunder one-move tactics: Thinking System and Tactical Patterns.
- I see ideas but cannot prove them: Calculation Method.
- I do not know what to do: Evaluation, Pieces, and Pawn Structures.
- My attacks vanish: Attacking the King.
- I collapse under pressure: Defense and Practical Play.
- I forget theory: Opening Principles and Repertoire.
- I fail to convert or hold: both Endgame volumes.
- I study without transfer: Training and Game Review.

PRACTICE RULE

Choose one symptom, one volume, and one measurable behavior for the next five games.

COMMON MISAPPLICATION

The most interesting subject is not always the highest-value subject.

Position Lab

Do not turn the page until you have written a candidate list or explanation. Score the process separately from whether your final answer is correct.

LAB 01

A move was tactically bad because you never noticed that moving a knight opened a rook line to your queen. Which error class and drill fit best?

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

LAB 02

You saw the correct candidate, calculated the line accurately, but rejected the favorable endgame because you overvalued bishop versus knight. Which class fits?

BEFORE CHECKING

Name the cue, list at least two candidates or explanations, and test the strongest objection.

Position Lab - Answers

LAB 01

This is primarily perception: a departure-square line change. Train a short blunder-shield set requiring you to state what each candidate stops defending before choosing.

LAB 02

Evaluation or knowledge, depending on whether you understood the structure. Study the resulting minor-piece ending and retry the leaf position, not only the original tactical sequence.

Daily Study Card

Use this as a compact recall sheet. Say each item without looking, then open the volume only for the item you cannot explain.

- Use the symptom-to-volume index.
- Tag the earliest failed decision step.
- Select one cue and one behavior to train.
- Test it across five serious games.
- Cycle back at a higher level of precision.

TRANSFER TEST

During your next five serious games, mark every position where this volume's cue appeared. Improvement means you noticed the cue and used a better process, even when the game result was noisy.

CONTINUE WITH

Return to 01_Thinking_System.pdf, now using positions from your own PGNs.

Personal notes